

IRONROOT Executive Distillation

A concise summary of the thread's game, narrative, and systems spine.

One-line thesis: IRONROOT is a deterministic gothic systems RPG where every death, memory, name, Shadow, and reset becomes a recorded consequence inside the Ironroot.

1. The Core Game

IRONROOT / The Thirteenth Moon is a 3D voxel metroidvania and dark fantasy action RPG built around one wound: the protagonist's spouse has been legally erased from memory, and Morrow's death teaches the player what erasure sounds and feels like. The game is not about saving the world first. It is about recovering one stolen name and discovering that the whole world exists to make that impossible.

The central invention is that narrative, combat, routing, and engine determinism are one system. The city does not simply contain lore about debt and memory. It executes debt and memory as physics.

2. Four Pillars

Pillar	Meaning	Player Experience
Name Erasure	Names are relational identity records, not labels.	A psychoacoustic Name-Shear tells the player a person has been removed from history.
Deterministic Haunting	Runs do not reset the world. They add event records.	Every death, siren, shortcut, Shadow, and faction move persists in the ledger.
Combat Aspects	Battles collapse the 3D world into different rule lenses.	Ledger = tactical law, Knife = 2D action, Root = dimensional hybrid, Vowless = refusal.
Progressive Disclosure	The game does not explain itself upfront.	Players learn by hearing, routing, failing, and eventually preventing erasures.

3. Player Knowledge Arc

Stage	Player Understanding	Game Function
0-2h	That sound is terrifying.	Opening trauma teaches the Name-Shear.
2-8h	The world changes after the sound.	Erasure becomes world-state mutation.
8-20h	I can follow the sound.	Spatial audio becomes navigation.
20-40h	These events are scheduled.	Faction clocks become readable.
40-70h	I can interrupt them.	Major erasures become boss/routing events.
70-100h	I can prevent them before they begin.	Speedrun mastery emerges from deterministic systems.

4. The Name-Shear

The Name-Shear is the signature sound of a name, spirit, debt, or memory relation being forcibly removed from record. It is introduced through Morrow's death and the spouse's erased grave, then returns as a distant world-state warning. The player hears it once as trauma, later as geography, then as a schedule, and finally as a preventable event.

Design law: The first time the player hears the Name-Shear, they suffer it. The tenth time, they follow it. The fiftieth time, they beat it there. The hundredth time, they prevent it from sounding.

5. Roguelike Identity

IRONROOT should not be a random-run roguelike. It should be deterministic haunting. The same root seed, same player actions, and same tick order produce the same result. The variability comes from routes, erasure schedules, faction pressure, death-routing, Shadow evolution, and the player's growing knowledge.

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Root Seed
-> World Layout
-> Zone Schedule
-> Faction Agenda
-> Erasure Schedule
-> Encounter Seed
-> Shadow Behavior
-> Combat Tick Simulation
-> Event Ledger
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6. Why This Has a 100-Hour Spine

The same location gains new meaning over time. A road is first a road, then a route, then a scheduled cleanse path, then a Shadow trap, then a faction economy, then an ending-pressure machine. This supports long play without needing content bloat.

7. Core Summary

The engine simulates resonance. Combat simulates dissonance. The roguelike layer simulates memory cost. The narrative asks whether grief must become power.